My five years at the Reserve Bank also marked an intellectually vigorous period for central banking around the world. Not only has the global financial crisis tested the policy force of central banks but it has also raised several questions about the tools of their trade, their forays into communication, the limits of their autonomy and the limitations of the manner in which they render accountability. Much of the debate surrounding these issues has been set in the advanced economy context. I have endeavoured to place some of these issues and debates in an Indian and emerging-market perspective.

The book is more than just about my challenges and dilemmas. It is also an attempt to demystify the Reserve Bank. Although monetary policy is the glamorous stuff that grabs the headlines, the Reserve Bank is much more than a narrow monetary authority. It has a broad mandate and a wide array of responsibilities. Yet the vast majority of people in India only have a scanty understanding of what the Reserve Bank does and how that affects their everyday lives. I have endeavoured to bridge that knowledge gap; a wider awareness of the functions and responsibilities of the RBI should help the larger public hold the Reserve Bank to account for results. Or that, at least, is my hope.

I did not keep any notes while serving as governor which ruled out a conventional memoir organized chronologically. Besides, I was more attracted to the idea of telling my stories and recounting my challenges thematically. The ordering of the chapters has, however, been informed by a rough chronological sequencing.

As I started on the book, I was apprehensive about whether I could recall the relevant details and reconstruct my experiences after a gap of over two years in the absence of any notes whatsoever. In the event, it did not prove to be as big a handicap as I feared. I depended almost entirely on press clippings, my speeches and the Reserve Bank publications of my period which helped me put together a narrative in as much detail as I wanted. Besides, the Internet was a handy and efficient resource for research and fact–checking.